

1964–1969

MINICOATS AND SKIRTS

With the fast-paced social scene of the swinging sixties came daring developments in fashion. The introduction of the mini mid-decade saw women wearing skirts that finished above the knee for the first time since the 1920s. Hemlines continued to rise, encouraged by the designs of Mary Quant and John Bates at Jean Varon, reaching a high of the mega-micro, 20 cm (8 in) above the knee. This controversially skimpy style was greeted by the older generation with raised eyebrows, but for young fashionistas the leggy look was an expression of a new freedom. Skirts were simple and neat but in bright, head-turning colours. Coats were similarly thigh-skimming, challenging the established notion that women should cover up their bodies. The iconic miniskirt left a lasting legacy, with designers returning to the shape again and again, beyond the 20th century and into the 21st.

MARY QUANT



British designer Mary Quant (1934–) launched her “London look” for the youth culture emerging in the capital. She created unique designs for the teenage market, including the micro-mini, and showcased them in the windows of her famous Chelsea boutique, Bazaar. The style was soon popularized and became mass-produced, with sales spreading across Europe.



Block colour In 1964 French designer André Courrèges included the new short style in his collection. This minidress and matching jacket in bright orange wool typifies the minimalist cut of his designs.



Asymmetric detail This simple wool coat, from 1967, shows Courrèges’s flair for subtle subversion of a traditional cut. The design features large patch pockets on the diagonal, and a metallic leather belt and buttons.



In Vogue This bright floral print coat dress by New York’s Originala fashion house was photographed for *Vogue* in 1968. The design features double-breasted button details, a large collar, and a contrasting belt in the style of a mac.



Belted mac This waterproof coat by US firm Weatherbee put a modern twist on the traditional mackintosh, first produced in the 1820s. Here, it is worn with white knee-high socks and Mary Jane shoes.